When I reflect on my stint with the Eastern Army, what comes foremost to mind is the complexities of the North-east not only in reference to our Northern Adversary but also the hugely intricate issues related to the internal security dynamics of the region. While the diversity of Indian nationhood is a matter of truism and amounts to stating the obvious, what is less spoken about is the fact that it is North-east (NE) India where this manifests to a scale that probably is unparalleled anywhere in the world. Our NE historically has been a melting pot of cultures and ethnicities. Over 500 different ethnic groups, of which around 110 are major, dot the landscape of our North-east Region (NER). Owing to its diverse ethnic sub-nationalism governed by primordial values of 'tribe–land–autonomy', the region got marred by various insurgencies over time. Multiple causative factors that were unique to each insurgency pushed the region into a vicious circle of violence in the immediate wake of Independence, thus disrupting the development and governance. However, one common thread impacting every insurgency has been the nefarious designs of our inimical adversaries as they were quick to exploit opportunities, giving various Indian Insurgent Groups (IIGs) readily available ideological, moral and material support. While the Chinese sowed the seeds with their precepts of communism to begin with and kept giving the necessary drip line and boosters from time to time; extended/thin deployment on the Indo–Bangladesh Border (IBB) was exploited by IIGs and the dispensation in erstwhile East Pakistan and subsequently by the Director General Foreign Intelligence (DGFI) of Bangladesh during the rule of Gen Zia and his daughter. Despite its friendly orientation, Myanmar, on the other hand, owing to its own internal challenges and the engulfing of the Myanmar Army (MA) in combating Ethnic Armed Groups (EAGs),

Copyright @ Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation